

Southern Company — Deepgram Account Brief

Generated 2026-10-05 · Depth: quick · Fit score: **69/100 (active prospect)** · Legend: [n] = sourced fact · **HYPOTHESIS** = hypothesis, verify · **Unknown** = not found

Facts come from web-search results, some from excerpts only (the company site, SEC, and job boards were blocked for direct fetch). Open the source before quoting a number to Southern Company.

TL;DR

- Who:** Atlanta utility holding company (NYSE: SO) serving ~9M electric and gas customers through Georgia Power, Alabama Power, Mississippi Power, and Southern Company Gas, with ~28,000 employees [1].
- Why now:** A new EVP & Chief Information Technology Officer (Hans Brown, Jul 2025) has a mandate for "data and analytics, AI, and innovation" [3], and the customer team is already building gen-AI on a customer lakehouse [7].
- Pain:** **HYPOTHESIS** Storm and billing peaks overwhelm the phone channel. Public posts describe 20–30+ minute holds and looping voice menus at Georgia Power [12].
- Motion:** **Co-sell via Five9.** SouthStar Energy (Southern Company Gas) runs Five9 for IVR, ACD, and "AI-driven tools" [9]. Land the speech layer there, then carry the proof to the gas utilities and Georgia Power.
- Win — key stakeholder:** **Kerry Hogan, VP Customer Experience, Southern Company Gas** [5]. She owns customer care, billing, collections, and digital experience design for 4.4M customers and leads the multi-year Digital Transformation Strategy. Exec sponsor for expansion: **Latanza Adjei** (Georgia Power CCO) [4]. Technical approver: **Hans Brown** [3].
- Ask:** "Your gen-AI work is giving you a 360° view of the customer. What happens to the millions of calls that still go through a menu?"

1. Account Snapshot

Company	Electric + gas utility holding co. · Atlanta, GA · NYSE: SO · founded 1945 [19]
Scale	4.59M retail electric customers (GA Power 2.83M, AL Power 1.56M, MS Power 0.19M) + ~4.4M gas customers; ~28,000 employees [1][5]
Strategy	CITO role created to drive "technology, data and analytics, AI, and innovation to meet customers' changing needs" (Jul 2025) [3]
Financial signal	Q2 2026 adjusted EPS \$1.13 vs. \$0.92; retail sales +2.3% YTD, the strongest in ~20 years, driven by data centers [2]
Relationship	No business contact with southernco.com found in Gmail or Calendar

2. Why Now

When	Trigger	So what for Deepgram
Nov 5, 2026	Q3 earnings call [18]	Listen for cost-to-serve and AI language to quote back
2026	Helene cost recovery (\$800M storm costs) deferred into 2026 under a base-rate freeze through 2028 [14][15]	Bill questions plus flat base rates → pressure to lower cost to serve
Jul 2025	Hans Brown (ex-BNY) named EVP & CITO [3]	New technical decision-maker, now ~15 months in and setting the AI roadmap
Mar 2025	DTECH talk: gen-AI, RAG, LLMs, and "AI agent deployment" on a customer lakehouse [7][8]	Text and data AI exists. Voice is the missing channel

3. Contact Center & Stack

Layer	Vendor (evidence)	Class → implication
CCaaS / omnichannel	Five9 at SouthStar Energy (IVR, ACD, chat, text, AI tools) [9]	Partner → co-sell. Unknown whether Five9 extends to the gas utilities or Georgia Power
Contact center QA / WFM	NICE SmartCenter as the standard across centers STALE (old article) [11]	Either → if still NICE, find which speech engine runs under analytics
Speech engine / IVR	Unknown . Public posts describe a multi-level voice menu [12]	Discovery Q1. HYPOTHESIS DTMF or directed-speech IVR
AI / data platform	Databricks and Azure AI named in AI Engineer posts [17]; CGI as data partner [7]	HYPOTHESIS Azure Speech is a likely default → bake-off
CRM / billing	Unknown	Integrate through the voice agent's tool calls

Ops & hiring: Southern Company Gas runs care centers in Riverdale, GA and Virginia Beach, VA (~200 employees under one manager) for Atlanta Gas Light, Chattanooga Gas, and Virginia Natural Gas [10], plus a Mississippi Power center in Gulfport, MS [13]. Georgia Power and Alabama Power center locations and headcount are **Unknown**.

4. Buying Committee

Person	Background	Likely role
Kerry Hogan — VP Customer Experience, Southern Company Gas [5]	At the company since 2006. Owns care, billing, collections, energy assistance, and digital experience design. Leads the multi-year Digital Transformation Strategy	Champion / economic buyer for the land. Best first meeting
Latanza Adjei — SVP & Chief Customer Officer, Georgia Power [4]	Joined 1994 (Georgia Tech IE). Previously VP Sales & Marketing and VP Corporate Services. Owns physical and digital channels	Exec sponsor for the largest expansion (2.8M customers)
Hans Brown — EVP & Chief Information Technology Officer [3]	Ex-BNY CIO and Global Head of Enterprise Innovation. Started Jul 31, 2025	Technical approver, vendor and AI strategy
Jesse Killings — SVP Customer Operations, Southern Company Gas [6]	Owns customer experience, resource management, and safety training	Kerry Hogan's line leader. Needs to sign off
Alexia Borden — SVP Customer & Community Engagement, Alabama Power [16]	Oversees Customer Operations and six business divisions	Later expansion sponsor (1.56M customers)

5. Pain → Deepgram Fit

Signal	HYPOTHESIS Pain	Deepgram answer + proof
Storm seasons; Helene was the most destructive storm in the utility's history [14]	Outage and restoration calls spike past staffing	Voice agent handles outage status and ETR calls at any volume. Covers peaks without overtime
Hold and menu complaints [12]	Callers can't get through menus and escape to agents	Nova accuracy on account numbers, addresses, and Southern accents. Five9 healthcare deployment doubled authentication rates
Gen-AI and lakehouse program [7]	AI investment so far covers text and data, not the phone	Voice Agent API with their own LLM and RAG, plugged into the lakehouse
Five9 at SouthStar [9]	Five9 IVA speech accuracy limits containment	Deepgram already powers STT inside Five9 IVA Studio. Upgrade, not a replacement

Signal	<i>HYPOTHESIS</i> Pain	Deepgram answer + proof
Regulated customer data and union workforces	Change and data-handling risk	VPC or on-prem deployment. Frame as helping agents with peaks, not reducing headcount

ROI sketch: Calls per year are **Unknown**. Assume 9M customers × ~1 call/yr = 9M calls (assumed). Conservative: 9M × 30% automatable × 50% containment × (\$4 – \$1.50) ≈ **\$3.4M/yr**. Midpoint: 9M × 40% × 60% × (\$6 – \$1) ≈ **\$10.8M/yr**. All inputs are playbook defaults except customer count [1].

6. Talk Track & Objections

- **Opener:** "You've built a 360° customer view and are deploying gen-AI agents on it. The phone is still where most of your customers show up on the worst day, during a storm. We'd like to see if a voice agent on your Five9 platform can take those calls."
- **Angles:** *Kerry Hogan:* containment and authentication by intent, peak coverage, energy-assistance and payment calls. *Hans Brown:* bring-your-own LLM, Azure or VPC deployment, one speech layer across opcos. *Latanza Adjei:* outage-season experience for 2.8M customers.
- **Proof:** Five9 healthcare deployment (2× authentication) and Abby Connect (100,000+ calls/month).

Objection	Response
"Five9 / our vendor already has AI"	Good. Deepgram runs inside Five9 IVA Studio, so this upgrades the speech layer you already own
"We're on Azure / Microsoft"	Bake-off on your recorded calls: accuracy on account numbers and addresses, latency, cost per hour. Deepgram can run in your VPC
"Regulators and unions"	Agents get the complex calls; the AI takes outage status and payment arrangements. Audio stays in your environment
"Rates are frozen; no budget"	Cost takeout under a rate freeze. Often lands in the existing Five9 line

7. Discovery Questions

1. "Which IVR and speech engine handle Georgia Power, Alabama Power, and the gas utilities' calls today? Is Five9 used beyond SouthStar?"
2. "How many calls a year do the care centers take, and what share is outage, billing, payment arrangement, or start/stop service?"
3. "What happened to call volume and service level during Helene, and what's the plan for the next major storm?"
4. "Your lakehouse team is deploying AI agents. Is voice on that roadmap, and who owns it: IT under Hans Brown or customer experience?"
5. "What would a pilot need to prove for regulators, the union, and your security team?"

8. Next Best Actions

1. **Five9 account team** (partner channel): confirm Five9 scope across Southern Company Gas and ask for a warm intro to Kerry Hogan.
2. **Kerry Hogan** (email after the intro): one paragraph on storm-season call coverage and the Five9 2× authentication proof; propose a 30-minute discovery call.
3. **Hans Brown** (LinkedIn or executive event): a note on the voice gap in the gen-AI program and a VPC bake-off offer.
4. Q3 earnings (Nov 5): capture any AI or cost-to-serve quote for the follow-up.

Fit score: Volume 27/30 · Pain 15/25 · Timing 13/20 · Stack 11/15 · Access 3/10 · Competitor adj –0 = **69/100**

Sources

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